

Olympic gold and I remember the first time I saw it in his showcase. I remember going, 'Wow! So that's what an Olympic medal looks like.' I thought, 'That's what it must be to complete hockey,'" he says.

Given his background, it was almost inevitable that Hardik would take up hockey too.

"I think hockey chose me. I was from a hockey family. We had a field too in the village where my

grandfather coached. Even when I was a kid there were at least 100 kids who were training there. One of my earliest memories is when Guru Nanak Dev University was hosting a match between India and Pakistan in Amritsar, and at half-time, my uncle took me to the centre of the field and I hit a few balls," he says.

Still, it was his grandfather who played the biggest role in nurturing his love for the sport.

"Every evening at 4 p.m., he would take me on the back of his scooter to the practice ground and I'd play until 7 p.m. Just to encourage me, he'd give me a little bit of pocket money every day. It was just 10 rupees. I'd buy a packet of Lay's chips or a bottle of Coke. I think I was bribed into liking hockey, but I did enjoy it," Hardik says.

It wasn't just daily practice — his grandfather also took him to trials and tournaments in the village.

"Whenever there was a tournament, he'd seat me on the back of his Activa and off we'd go. As a kid, I've seen so many international players. Even at that age, I'd be really fascinated," he says.

Even after moving to academies in Jalandhar and later Mohali, Hardik would frequently return to Khusropur and even the neighbouring village of Sansarpur for tournaments.

"I remember once competing at a competition in Sansarpur and I saw

